

On Humor

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On Humor

LUIGI PIRANDELLO

Humor was the subject of a course of lectures given by Pirandello in Rome. The first edition of the essay came out in 1908; the "second, enlarged edition," from which the following is taken, came out in 1920 (Luigi Battistelli, Florence).—Editor's note.

Comedy and its opposite lie in the same disposition of feeling, and they are inside the process which results from it. In its abnormality, this disposition is bitterly comical, the condition of a man who is always out of tune; of a man who is at the same time violin and bass; of a man for whom no thought can come to mind unless suddenly another one, its opposite and contrary, intervenes; of a man for whom any one reason for saying yes is at once joined by two or three others compelling him to say no, so that yes and no keep him suspended and perplexed for all his life; of a man who cannot let himself go in a feeling without suddenly realizing something inside which disturbs him, disarranges him, makes him angry. . . .

It is a special psychic phenomenon, and it is absolutely arbitrary to attribute to it any determining cause. It may be the result of a bitter experience with life and man—an experience that doesn't allow one the naïve feeling of putting on wings and flying like a lark chirping in the sunshine: it pulls at the tail when one is ready to fly. On the other hand, it leads to the thought that man's sadness is often caused by life's sadness, by evils so numerous that not everyone knows how to take them. It leads to the reflection that life, though it has not ordained a clear end for human reason, does not require me to wander in the dark, a reflection that is peculiar and illusive for each man, large or small. It is not important, though, since it is not, nor may it be, the real end which all eagerly try to find and which nobody finds—maybe because it does not exist. The important thing is to give importance to something, vain as it might be. It will be valued as much as something

serious, and in the end neither will give satisfaction, because it is true that the ardent thirst for knowledge will always last, the faculty of wishing will never be extinguished—though it cannot be said that man's happiness consists in his progress.

All the soul's fictions and the creations of feeling are subjects for humor; we will see reflection becoming a little devil which disassembles the machine of each image, of each fantasy created by feeling; it will take it apart to see how it is made; it will unwind its spring, and the whole machine will break convulsively. Perhaps humor will do this with the sympathetic indulgence about which those who see only a kind of good humor speak. But it ought not to be trusted. . . .

Every feeling, thought, and idea which arises in the humorist splits itself into contraries. Each yes splits itself into a no, which assumes at the end the same value as the yes. Sometimes the humorist may pretend to take only one side; meanwhile, inside, the other feeling speaks out to him, and appears although he doesn't have the courage to reveal it. It speaks to him and starts by advancing now a faint excuse, an alternative, which cools off the warmth of the first feeling, and then a wise reflection which takes away seriousness and leads to laughter.

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If one sees in humor a particular contrast between ideal and reality, it means that it has been considered superficially and from one aspect only. An ideal may exist—this depends on the personality of the poet—but if it exists, it needs to be analyzed, limited, and represented in this way. Surely, like all the other elements in the spirit of a poet, it enters and is felt in any humorous work. It gives to it a particular character and particular taste. But it isn't a pre-established condition. Just the opposite: it is characteristic of any humorist, through his special kind of reflection, which creates the feeling of incongruity, of not knowing any more which side to take amid the perplexities and irresolutions of his conscience.

This characteristic already distinguishes the humorous from the comic, the ironical, and the satirical. In these no feeling of incongruity arises. If it did arise, it would be bitter, that is: no longer humorous. When laughter is aroused by the first realization of any given abnormality, any purely verbal contradiction between what is

said and what is to be understood becomes effective, substantial, and therefore no longer ironical; disdain no longer exists, at least not as that inversion of reality which is the reason for any satire.

It is not that reality pleases a humorist. Even if he likes it for an instant, reflection working on this pleasure ruins it. Reflection insinuates itself sharply and subtly everywhere, and it disarranges everything: each image of feeling, each ideal fiction, each flash of reality, each illusion.

Man's thought, said Guy de Maupassant, "goes around like a fly in a bottle." All phenomena either are illusory or their reason escapes us inexplicably. Our knowledge of the world and of ourselves refuses to be given the objective value which we usually attempt to attribute to it. Reality is a continuously illusory construction.

Do we want to assist in the fight between illusion, which insinuates itself everywhere and builds things up in its own way, and humorous reflection, which analyzes these constructions one by one?

Let us start, then, from the construction that illusion offers each of us: the image that everyone has of himself through the work of our illusions. Do we see ourselves in our true reality, as we really are, and not as what we would like to be? Through a spontaneous interior artifice, the result of hidden tendencies or unconscious imitations, don't we believe ourselves to be, in good faith, different from what in substance we are? And we think, work, live according to this factitious but at the same time sincere interpretation of ourselves.

Now, yes, reflection can reveal to the comic and the satirical as well as the humorous writer this concept of illusions. The comic only laughs at it, being pleased to blow away this metaphor of himself created by a spontaneous illusion. The satirical writer will be upset by it. But not the humorist: through the ridiculous side of this perception he will see the serious and grievous side of it. He will analyze the illusion, but not with the intention of laughing at it. Instead of feeling disdain he will, rather, in his laughter, feel commiseration.

The comic and satirical writers know, through reflection, how much nourishment the spider of experience takes from social life to form the web of morality in any person. And they know how often what is called the moral sense remains trapped in this web. In the long run, what *are* arrangements of so-called social convenience? Calculated considerations, in which morality is almost always sacrificed. The

humorist goes deeper, and he laughs without disdain on finding out how, with naïveté, with the best good faith, through the spontaneous work of fiction, we are led to interpret as real feeling, as real moral sense in itself, what is nothing but a feeling of *convenience*, that is, of mental calculation. He goes even further, and discovers that even the need to appear worse than what one really is may become conventional, if one is associated with a social group whose characteristic ideas and feelings are inferior to what one might desire for oneself.

The conciliation of discordant tendencies, of disagreeable feelings, of contrary opinions, seems to be more effectively carried out by a common lie than by an explicit and manifest tolerance of discord and contrast. It appears that, in effect, a lie is more advantageous than the truth, insofar as the lie can unite whereas the truth divides. This is not obviated by the fact that the lie is secretly revealed and recognized and truth itself is then assumed as a guarantee of its effective association, through which hypocrisy comes to look like sincerity.

Caution, secrecy, imagining too much about what one says or does, the same silence with knowledge of signs which justify it . . . are artifices which are frequently used in everyday practice. Care may be taken not to permit someone to know what one thinks, letting him believe that one is thinking less than one is really thinking, to attempt to be seen as different from what one really is.

Rousseau remarked in his *Emile*:

One may do what has been done and ought not to have been done. Perhaps a greater interest can cause the violation of a promise made for a lesser interest, but what is important is that the violation occur with impunity. The means to this end is the lie, which can be of two kinds. In order to look back at the past, we call ourselves the authors of what we really have not done, or maybe say that we have not done such and such which we really have done. The other kind we use to look into the future, as when we make promises which we don't have any intention of keeping. It is clear that the lie, in either case, arises as a convenience, as a means of keeping people's favor and seizing people's aid.

The more difficult the fight for life, the more one's weaknesses and the greater the need for mutual deception. To simulate strength, honesty, sympathy, prudence—in effect, all virtues, especially truthfulness—is a form of adaptation, and a valuable tool in the struggle.

The humorist soon catches these various dissimulations in the fight

for life. He enjoys himself in uncovering them and doesn't feel any disdain. "It is so!"

While a sociologist describes social life as he objectively observes it, the humorist, armed with his sharp intuition, shows and reveals how appearances are vastly different from what goes on in his associates' unconscious. Indeed we lie psychologically just as we lie socially. Lying to ourselves by living consciously only on the surface of our psychological being is a result of the social lie. The soul which reflects upon itself is a lonely soul; but loneliness is never so great that suggestions of common life don't penetrate the consciousness, with the punishments and transfigurative artifices which characterize it.

The soul of our race—or the collectivity of which we are a part—lives in each individual soul. The pressures of others' judgment, of other people's ways of feeling and acting, are felt by us in the unconscious. As in the world, social simulation and dissimulation dominate. They are less noticed the more common they become. In the same way we simulate and dissimulate with ourselves, splitting or even multiplying ourselves. We resent that need to appear different from what we really are which is a form of social life. We shun any analysis which, revealing vanity, would awaken the bite of our conscience and humiliate us in front of ourselves. But the humorist makes this analysis for us. He can even assume the job of unmasking all vanities and representing society—Thackeray does just this in *Vanity Fair*.

The humorist knows well that the pretense of logic is much greater in us than real logical coherence, because if we feign logic, the logic of our actions reveals the logic of our thoughts by showing that it is fiction to believe in its absolute sincerity. Habit, unconscious imitation, mental laziness help in creating the equivocal.

And is the rapport that we make with reason always sincere, when with it, with rigorously logical reason, we enunciate our respect and love for established ideals? Is the pure, the unselfish reason always the only and true source of ideals and of that perseverance which maintains them? Isn't it correct, rather, to suspect that sometimes ideals are supported not by objective and rational criteria but by special affective impulses and obscure tendencies?

The obstacles and the limitations which we place upon our consciousness are also illusions. They are the conditions of the appearance of our relative individuality. In reality, these limitations do not exist.

Not only do we, as we are now, live within ourselves, but also we, as we were formerly, live now and feel and reason with thoughts and feelings already forgotten, erased, dead in our present consciousness. At a blow, at a sudden shake of the spirit, these can still give signs of life, revealing within ourselves another unsuspected being. The limitations of our personal, conscious memory are not absolute. Beyond that line there are memories, perceptions, reasonings. What we know about ourselves is but a part, perhaps a very small part of what we really are. . . .

Indeed, the various tendencies which mark a personality lead us to think seriously that the individual soul is not *one*. How can we indeed say that it is one, if passion and reason, instinct and will, tendency and ideals, constitute equivalent systems, distinct and changeable, which decide that a person, living now in one, then in the other, now in a compromise between two or more psychological components, appears really to have within himself several different and even opposite souls, to say nothing of opposite personalities? Pascal said, "There is no man who is more different from any other than he is from himself once in a while."

Simplicity of soul contradicts the historical concept of the human soul. Its life is a changing equilibrium, a continuous awakening and slumbering of feelings, tendencies and ideas. It is an incessant fluctuation between contradictory terms, an oscillation between opposite poles: hope and fear, truth and falsehood, beauty and ugliness, right and wrong, and so on. If suddenly in the dark image of the future a brilliant plan of action is drawn, or vaguely a flower of pleasure shines, soon there also appears, as a result of experience, the thought of the past, often dark and sad; or the feeling of the agitated present intervenes to bridle the happy fancy. This conflict of memories, hopes, prophecies, presentiments, perceptions, and ideals can be represented as a conflict of souls among themselves; all are fighting for the definite and full power of personality.

Let's look at an executive, who believes in himself and is a gentleman. The moral is predominant in him. But one day the instinctive soul, which is like a wild beast hidden deep in everybody, gives a kick to his moral soul and the gentleman steals. Now that poor man is the first one who after a while is shocked, cries, and desperately asks himself, "How, how could I have done this?"

But—yes, sir—he has stolen. What about another man? A well-to-do man, indeed a rich man, he has killed. The moral ideal constituted in his personality a soul which was in conflict with his instinctive soul; it constituted an acquired soul which fought with his hereditary soul, which, left free to itself for a while, succeeded in committing crime.

Life is a continuous flow which we continually try to stop, to fix in established and determinate forms outside and inside of ourselves because we are already fixed forms, forms that move among other immovable ones, which follow the flow of life until the point when they become rigid and their movement, slowed, stops. The forms in which we try to stop and fix this continuous flow are the concepts, the ideals, within which we want to keep coherent all the fictions we create, the condition and the status in which we try to establish ourselves. But inside ourselves, in what we call our soul, which is the life in us, the flow continues indistinctly, under the wire, past the limits that we set when we formed consciousness and built a personality. During certain stormy moments, inundated by the flow, all our fictitious forms collapse ignominiously. Even what doesn't flow under the wire and beyond the limits—what is revealed distinctly in us carefully channelled by our feelings, in the duties which we have imposed upon ourselves, in the habits that we have formed—in certain moments of flood overflows and topples everything.

There are some restless spirits, almost in a continuous state of confusion, who do not freeze into this or that personality. But even for the quiet ones, those who find rest in one form or other, fusion is always possible. The flow of life is in everybody.

Therefore, it can be, sometimes, a torture for everyone that, in contrast to the soul that moves and changes, our body should be fixed forever in unchanging features. Why are we made exactly so? We sometimes ask the mirror, "Why this face, this body?" We lift a hand; in the unconscious, the act remains suspended. It seems strange that we have done it. *We see ourselves alive*. In that suspended gesture we look like a statue—like that statue of an ancient orator, for example, whom we see in a niche, climbing the stairs of the Quirinal. He has a scroll in one hand and the other hand lifted in a severe gesture. How sad and surprised that ancient orator seems to be that he has remained there, through so many centuries, suspended in that gesture, while so many persons have climbed, are climbing, and will climb those stairs!

During certain moments of interior silence, during which our soul sheds all habitual functions, and our eyes become sharper and more penetrating, we see ourselves in life and we see life as an arid barrenness. Disconcerted, we feel as if taken by a strange impression, as if, in a flash, a different reality from the one we usually perceive were revealed to us, a living reality beyond human vision, beyond the forms of human vision. Very clearly, then, the facts of daily existence, almost suspended in the vacuum of our interior silence, appear to us meaningless and without scope. That different reality appears horrible to us in its stern and mysterious crudeness because all our fictitious relationships, both of feelings and images, have split and disintegrated in it. The interior vacuum expands, surpasses the limits of our body, becomes a vacuum around ourselves, a strange vacuum like a stop of time and life, as our interior silence plunges itself into the abyss of mystery. With a supreme effort we try, then, to recapture the normal sense of things, to tie ourselves again to the usual relationships, to reassemble ideas, to feel alive in the usual way. But we cannot trust this normal consciousness, these rearranged ideas any more because we know now that they are deceptions which man needs to save himself from death or insanity. It was an instant, but its impressions will last for a long time, with a dizziness in contrast to the stability, quite specious, of things, ambitions, and miserable appearances. Life, which goes on as usual among these appearances, seems as if it isn't real any more. It seems a mechanical phantasmagoria. How can one give importance to it? How can one respect it?

Today we exist, tomorrow we will not. Which face have they given us to represent part of a living person? An ugly nose? How painful to walk around with an ugly nose for the rest of our life! It is good for us that after a while we don't pay any more attention to it. Then we don't know why other people laugh when they look at us. They are so silly! Let us console ourselves by looking at somebody else's lips, one who doesn't even realize it and doesn't have the courage to laugh at us. Masks, masks. They disappear in a breath, giving way to others. A poor lame man, who is he? Running toward death on crutches. Here life steps on somebody's foot, there it blinds somebody's eye—wooden leg, glass eye, and it goes on. Each one fixes his mask up as he can, the exterior mask.

Because inside there is another one, often contradicting the one

outside. Nothing is true! True is: the sea, the mountain, a rock, a blade of grass. But man: always wearing a mask, unwillingly, without knowing it, without wanting it, always masked with that thing which he, in good faith, believes to be handsome, good, gracious, generous, unhappy, and so on.

This is funny, if we stop to think of it. Yes, because a dog, after the first ardor of life, is gone, eats and sleeps; he lives as he can, as he ought to. He shuts his eyes, with patience, and lets time go by, cold if it is cold, warm if it is warm. If they kick him he takes it because it means that he deserved it. But what about man? Even when he is old he always has that *fever*; he is delirious and doesn't realize it. He cannot help posing, even in front of himself, in any way, and he imagines so many things which he needs to believe are true, which he needs to take seriously.

He is helped in this by an infernal little machine which nature presented him with, fixing it inside him to show him her good disposition toward him. Man, for his own sake, ought to have let it rust, ought never to have moved it or been so privileged, having it, that he started doggedly to improve it. Even Aristotle wrote a gracious booklet, which is still used in our schools today, so that children can learn soon and well enough how to play with it. It is a kind of pump with a filter which puts brain and heart in communication.

Philosophers call it logic. The brain pumps feelings from the heart and derives ideas from them. In the filter, passion leaves whatever it has that is warm or dark; it cools off, purifies itself, i-d-e-a-l-i-z-e-s itself. A poor feeling, aroused by a particular case, by any contingency, often sad, is pumped and filtered by the brain through that little machine and becomes a general, abstract idea. What happens then? It happens that we don't feel sorry only for that particular case, for that momentous contingency; we intoxicate our lives with that concentrated extract, with that corrosive sublimate of logical deduction. Many fools believe they can heal in this way all the ills of which the world is full, and they pump and filter, pump and filter until their hearts are dry as a piece of cork and their brain is like a closet full of drugs and bottles which wear a black label with a skull and crossbones.

Man doesn't have any absolute idea or knowledge of life, but only a variable feeling changing with the times, conditions, and luck. Now logic, by extracting ideas from feelings, tries, indeed, to fix what is

mobile and flowing. It tries to give an absolute value to what is relative, and it makes more serious an illness which is already serious by itself because its first root is in this feeling which we have about life. A tree lives, but it doesn't feel itself: to it earth, sun, air, light, wind, and rain aren't things which it isn't. To man, instead, is given at birth the sad privilege of feeling himself alive, with the illusions which come from it—namely to assume a reality outside himself and that interior feeling of life, changeable and variable.

Ancient people had a myth about Prometheus, who stole a spark from the sun to make a gift to man. Now, our feeling of life is indeed this Promethean spark. It enables us to see ourselves lost on this earth; it projects all around us a ring of light more or less large, beyond which there is shadow, frightening darkness which wouldn't exist if that spark had not been lit in us; but we must believe the shadow to be true, as long as that spark is alive in our hearts. When it is extinguished by the blow of death, that fictitious shadow will really receive us; the perpetual night will accept us after the smoky day of our illusion. Or will we remain at the mercy of that Being who will have only broken the vain forms of human reason? All that shadow, that enormous mystery, which so many philosophers have in vain speculated about, which science doesn't deny, even by renouncing it in order to analyze it, is perhaps another deception, like the other a deception of our mind, a fantasy which is not colored. And what if all this mystery, in effect, exists not outside but only within ourselves, and is necessary for our sentiments about life? What if death is only a blow which extinguishes in us this painful feeling, this ring of fictitious shadow beyond the small, faint light which we project around ourselves and in which our life is imprisoned? We seem excluded for a time from universal and external life, to which we feel we must return someday, while in reality we are already in it and will remain in it, but without the feeling of exile which frightens us.

Isn't this limitation of our personality illusory and relative to our faint light? Perhaps we always have lived and always will live with the universe. Even now, in this form of ours, we are participating in all manifestations of the universe. We do not know it, we don't see it, because, unfortunately, that spark which Prometheus wanted to give us lets us see only that little which it illuminates.

Tomorrow a humorous writer could represent Prometheus on the

Caucasus in the act of looking melancholically at his burning torch and discovering in it, finally, the fateful cause of his infinite punishment. He realizes at last that Jupiter is only his own fantasy, a miserable deception, the shadow of his own body which projects itself gigantically in the sky, just because of the burning torch which he has in his hands. Jupiter could disappear on one condition, that Prometheus extinguish his torch. But Prometheus doesn't know how, he doesn't want to, he cannot. That shadow remains, frightening and tyrannical for all men who don't realize the fateful deception.

Thus the contrast without escape, indivisible as is the body from the soul. We have seen it in this rapid vision expanding itself, surpassing the limits of the personality in which it is rooted, and expanding itself all about. Reflection has seen it, the reflection which sees in all an illusive construction of feelings and with intelligent, subtle, and minute analysis takes all apart and analyzes it.

One of the greatest humorists, without knowing it, was Copernicus, who took apart not the machine of the universe, but the proud image which we had made of it. . . . The discovery of the telescope gave the finishing stroke. This is another infernal machine, comparable to the one which nature wanted to give us. But we invented this one. Instead of being less than nature, with the eye looking from the bottom, out of the smaller lens, and seeing what nature mercifully wanted us to see small, what does our soul do? It jumps to look from the top, so that the telescope becomes a terrible instrument, which destroys earth, man, and all our glory and greatness.

Luckily, we have humorous reflection, from which stems the feeling of incongruity, which in this case says, "But is man really as small as an inverted telescope wants us to see him?" If he can understand and realize his infinite smallness, it means that he also understands and realizes the infinite greatness of the universe. How can we say, then, that man is small? But it is also true that if he feels himself big and a humorist happens to know it, he can have happen to him what happened to Gulliver, the giant in Lilliput who became a toy in the hands of the giants of Brobdingnag.

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From what we have said up to this point about the special activity of reflection in the humorist, the intimate process of humorous art clearly and necessarily develops.

Art, like all ideal or illusory constructions, has the tendency to fix life. It stops it at one moment or in various moments—a statue in a gesture, a landscape in a momentary unchangeable aspect. But what about the perpetual mobility of our successive aspects? What about the continuous fusion in which souls find themselves?

Art in general abstracts and concentrates; that is, it catches and represents only the essential and characteristic ideality of men and things. Now, it appears to the humorist that all this oversimplifies nature, attempting to make life too reasonable, or at least too coherent. It seems to him that art in general does not take into consideration what it ought to, art doesn't consider causes, the real causes which often move this poor human life to strange, absolutely unpredictable actions. For a humorist, causes in real life are never as logical and ordered as in our common works of art, in which all is, in effect, combined and organized to exist within the scope which the writer has in mind. Order? Coherence? What if we have within ourselves four souls fighting among themselves: the instinctive soul, the moral soul, the affective soul, and the social soul? Our consciousness adapts itself according to whichever dominates, and we hold as valid and sincere a false interpretation of our real interior being, which we ignore because it never makes itself manifest as a whole, but now in one way, now in another, according to the circumstances of life.

Yes, an epic or dramatic poet may represent a hero in whom opposite and unacceptable elements are shown fighting; but he will create a character out of these elements and make him coherent in his actions. Well, the humorist will do exactly the reverse: he will take the character apart. While the poet is careful to make him coherent in each action, the humorist is amused by representing him in his incongruities.

A humorist does recognize heroes; even better, he lets others represent them. He, for his own sake, knows what legend is and how it is formed; he knows what history is and how it is formed. They are all compositions more or less ideal; perhaps they are the more ideal if they show a greater pretense of reality. He amuses himself by taking them apart, and one cannot say that this is a pleasant amusement.

He sees the world, if not entirely naked, let's say in only its shirt-sleeves. He sees a king in his shirtsleeves, a king who makes a beautiful impression in the majesty of his throne, with his royal staff and crown, his purple robe and ermine. Don't lay people with too much pomp on

their deathbeds, in their funeral chambers, because he is capable of profaning even this composition, this scene. He is capable of catching, amid the sadness of the spectators, in that cold and rigid corpse, with his decorations and good suit on, a certain lugubrious grumble of the stomach, an exclamation (since these things are best expressed in Latin), "*Digestio post mortem.*" . . . Carlyle says in his *Sartor Resartus*: "Man is a dressed-up animal, society has dresses for measurement." Even vestment composes, *composes and hides*—two things which humor cannot stand.

Bare life, nature without order—at least not apparent order—full of contradictions, is, for the humorist, very far from the ideal plan of common artistic conceptions in which all the elements clearly hold together and cooperate with each other.

In reality, actions which project a certain character are depicted on a background of ordinary facts and common incidents. Well, in general writers don't use them, or don't pay any attention to them, as if these incidents, these facts, do not have any value and are useless and of no importance. The humorist treasures them. Don't we find, in nature, gold mixed with earth? Well, ordinary writers throw the earth away and present the gold in new coins, melted and well-blended, well-weighed and stamped with the hallmark of the mint. But the humorist knows that ordinary incidents, common facts, the material of life so varied and complex, sharply contradict those ideal simplifications. They take actions, they inspire thoughts and feelings contrary to the whole harmonious logic of facts and characters created by ordinary writers.

And what about the unseen part of life? The abyss which exists in our soul? Don't we often feel a spark inside ourselves, strange thoughts like flashes of folly, illogical thoughts we dare not confide even to ourselves, arising from a soul different from the one we recognize in ourselves? For these, we have in humor research into the most intimate and minute particulars—which might look vulgar or trivial if compared with the ideal syntheses of most art—and work based on contrasts and contradictions in opposition to the coherence sought by the others. We have that disorganized, untied, and capricious element, all the digressions which are seen in a humorous work in opposition to the orderly plan, the *composition*, of most works of art.

They are the result of reflection, which dissects—"If Cleopatra's

nose had been longer, who knows what course the world would have had?" This *if*, this little element that can be pinned down, inserted like a wedge in all facts, can produce many different disaggregations; it can cause many disarrangements at the hand of a humorist who, like Sterne for example, sees the whole world regulated by infinite smallnesses.

Let's conclude: humor is the feeling of polarity aroused by that special activity of reflection which doesn't hide itself, which doesn't become, as ordinarily in art, a form of feeling, but its contrary, following the feelings step by step, however, as the shadow follows the body. A common artist pays attention only to the body. A humorist pays attention to the body and its shadow, sometimes more to the shadow than the body. He sees all the tricks of the shadow; it now assumes length or width, as if to mimic the body, which, meanwhile, doesn't pay any attention to it.

In the comic medieval representations of the devil we find a student who plays pranks on him and challenges him to catch his own shadow against the wall. He who represented this devil was not, certainly, a humorist. Only a humorist knows how much a shadow is worth—Chamisso's *Peter Schlemihl* will tell you.

Translated by TERESA NOVEL